

Ukubona LLC's Personal Meeting Room

Quick recap

The meeting focused on planning NIH grant applications, with particular emphasis on chronic kidney disease (CKD) and HIV research. Ukubona presented a digital platform being developed to track grant opportunities and progress, highlighting two immediate priorities with deadlines in June and September. The team discussed potential collaborators at Johns Hopkins and Emory University, with particular focus on surveillance research and cohort studies. They agreed to prioritize identifying a lead collaborator who could propel the application forward and demonstrate strong interest in the African setting. The group also discussed leveraging UCU's connections with Protestant Medical Bureau and local hospitals as potential collaborators, noting that faith-based facilities tend to be more task-oriented than government facilities.

Next steps

- Ukubona: Update and reorganize the grant opportunities document to explicitly sort by deadline, include direct links to grant announcements, and add columns for topic, checklist, and lead assignee; send updated version to team for feedback before the next meeting (target: this weekend). 📅
- Ukubona: Develop and implement a password-protected collaborative app/platform with dynamic checklists, progress tracking, and notification features for grant application tasks; have a functional version ready for review at the next meeting in two weeks. 📅
- Ukubona: Research and provide a list of potential collaborators (especially from Emory University, Johns Hopkins, and other relevant institutions), including specific names and contact information, and begin outreach to identify likely leads for the priority grant applications. 📅
- All team members: Review the updated grant opportunities document and app/platform when shared, and provide feedback, especially regarding prioritization and completeness of checklists, before the next meeting. 📅

- Boniface, Emmanuel, Robert, and team: Begin identifying and reaching out to potential collaborators, especially those with surveillance and HIV/drug use expertise, and report progress before the next meeting. 📅
- Ukubona: Summarize key information from NIH grant announcements (e.g., RFA details) and incorporate into the collaborative platform to aid team understanding and application preparation. 📅
- Ukubona: Coordinate with team to schedule an in-person meeting in Munyono (or nearby) at a mutually convenient time within the next two weeks. 📅

Summary

Uganda Digital Platform Updates

Ukubona provided updates on their work in Uganda, explaining they were there due to an unexpected backlog of Ugandan clients who prefer in-person meetings. They demonstrated a digital twin platform being developed, which includes password-protected portals for various clients including the Ministry of Education and Uganda National Planning Authority. The discussion appeared to be cut off as they were about to review announcements and their deadlines, which was a topic from their previous meeting.

Chronic Kidney Disease Research Focus

The team discussed their focus on chronic kidney disease (CKD), covering risk factors, stages, and related topics including dialysis and transplant tourism. They highlighted specific risk factors relevant to Africa, such as HIV and low birth weight, and noted that APOL1 gene interactions with HIV are more common in people of recent African ancestry. Potential funders for CKD research were identified, primarily NIDDK for diabetes and diet-related aspects, while NIAID would be relevant for HIV-related research.

HIV Application Deadline Planning

Boniface and Ukubona discussed upcoming deadlines, particularly for HIV-related applications, noting that the current monthly deadline for HIV status will expire by the end of the year. They determined that September is a more realistic deadline than May or June for submitting applications. Ukubona acknowledged the need to better prioritize the identified areas,

including two active trucks and CKD (Chronic Kidney Disease), and committed to creating a prioritized list for their next meeting.

Grant Tracking System Update

Ukubona discussed updating a grant tracking system to be organized by deadline rather than topic, with plans to implement a password-protected app featuring a checklist system to track progress on various grant requirements. The system will include clickable links to grant announcements and applications, with potential for notifications via the app, WhatsApp, and SMS to remind the team of upcoming deadlines. Ukubona committed to delivering this updated system with proper deadline sorting and URL links by the next meeting in two weeks.

Task Prioritization and Tracking System

The team discussed ongoing prioritization challenges and agreed to implement a tracking system using an app to manage tasks across collaborations more effectively. Ukubona proposed creating dynamic checklists that can be edited and tracked with progress indicators, suggesting this would help the team move forward more deliberately. Robert emphasized the need to develop a work plan with timelines and suggested that team members review shared materials before the next meeting in two weeks, at which point they should be ready for action.

Workflow Streamlining and Task Management

Emmanuel and Ukubona discussed streamlining their workflow by creating a checklist with ranked tasks and designated weekly leads to better distribute effort and track progress. They agreed that this approach would help identify potential bottlenecks and ensure tasks don't stall when team members are overbooked. Ukubona proposed adding a column to track weekly leads for specific topics, and mentioned their plan to develop a digital platform to enhance collaboration and make weekly progress more visible.

Grant Application Partnership Planning

The team discussed two upcoming deadlines for grant applications - one in June and another in September focused on a variant system for people who use and inject drugs. Boniface emphasized the importance of building strong partnerships and teams rather than rushing to meet deadlines, suggesting they prioritize identifying appropriate collaborators over selecting

specific topics. Ukubona agreed to update the document with these two priorities and begin exploring potential partners, particularly noting that Emory University might be a good fit for surveillance-focused work due to their alignment with CDC, while Johns Hopkins is stronger in cohort studies.

NIH Grant Collaboration Planning

The team discussed identifying potential collaborators for an NIH grant application, with Ukubona leading the discussion on reaching out to specific researchers including Shruti from Johns Hopkins and Hasina Samji from University of British Columbia. They agreed to focus on presenting a compelling knowledge gap in drug abuse surveillance in Africa, positioning the project as potentially becoming the next long-term study like the successful Rakai project. The team also discussed the importance of having a strong lead collaborator who is interested in the African setting, and Robert mentioned their existing network through Protestant Medical Bureau and affiliated hospitals which could provide easier entry points for collaboration.